

CUSTOMIZED EMPLOYMENT FOR TRANSITION-AGE YOUTH: AN ACTION RESEARCH PROJECT



INTRODUCTION

Think College Transition staff and school partners created an action research project to increase community-based employment opportunities for transition-age students with intellectual and developmental disabilities. As a professional development model, participants found action research to be an effective model for both learning and simultaneously implementing customized employment strategies.

THE CASE FOR A CUSTOMIZED APPROACH

Despite a growing number of initiatives aimed at improving employment outcomes for transition-age youth with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD), there remains a distinct and persistent lack of paid employment opportunities for this population (Hughes & Avoke, 2010; Nicholas, Luecking, & Luecking, 2006). Customized employment represents a possible solution to better outcomes for many populations with employment challenges, (Griffin, Hammis, Geary, & Sullivan, 2008; Nicholas, Luecking, & Luecking, 2006), in large part due to its dual-customer focus by meeting the needs of both the job seeker and employers.

OUR CHALLENGES

- » Time constraints
- » Employer reticence
- » Mindset shift
- » Transportation challenges
- » Liability concerns (fading supports)
- » Adult Services capacity
- » Family engagement

OUR NEXT STEPS

- » Further develop training series to scale
- » Expand to other districts
- » Develop products for online repository

REFERENCES

- Griffin, C., Hammis, David, & Geary, T., Sullivan, M. (2008). Customized Employment: Where we are; where we're headed. *Journal of Vocational Rehabilitation*, 28(3), 135-139.
- Hughes, C.; Avoke, S. (2010). The Elephant in the Room: Poverty, Disability, and Employment. *Research & Practice for Persons with Severe Disabilities*, 35(1-2), 5-14.
- Nicholas, R., Luecking, R. & Martin-Luecking, D. (2006). Customized employment: From practice to policy. *Journal of Applied Rehabilitation Counseling*, 37, pp. 36-42.
- Riel, M. (2016). Understanding Action Research. Retrieved from Center for Collaborative Action Research: <http://cadres.pepperdine.edu/ccar/define.html>

OUR ACTION RESEARCH MODEL

3 SCHOOL DISTRICTS > TRAINING SERIES > EMPLOYER ENGAGEMENT WORKSHOP

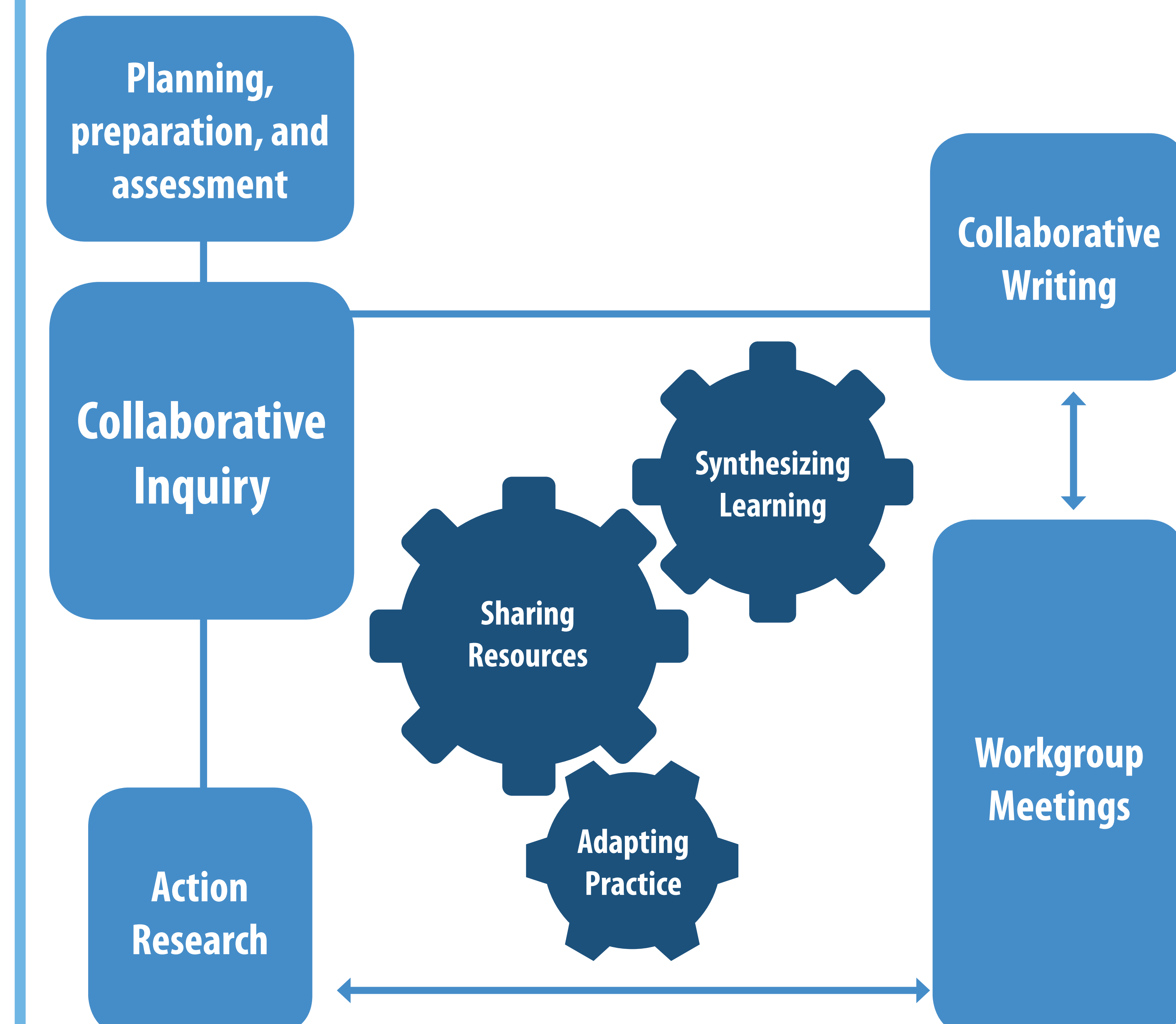


GOAL=IMPROVE PRACTICE & STUDENT EMPLOYMENT OUTCOMES!

CUSTOMIZED EMPLOYMENT PROCESS IN ACTION: A CASE STUDY



COLLABORATIVE INQUIRY AS A PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT TOOL



WHAT IS THE THINK COLLEGE TRANSITION PROJECT?

The TCT Project is an inclusive comprehensive college based transition project where students are fully included on campus in all aspects of a complete college experience, receiving supports as necessary (e.g., coaching and/or peer mentor, disability services office). This project offers an innovative approach to transition services for students with intellectual disabilities and autism by providing participation in inclusive academic and social environments of a college campus with same-aged peers rather than continuing to receive transition services in typical high school environments.

Think College at the Institute for Community Inclusion, at the University of Massachusetts Boston received funding from the US Department of Education, Investing In Innovation Fund (i3) to develop and implement the TCTP. Researchers at Education Development Center (EDC) will conduct the external evaluation of the TCT Model. Project matching funds have been provided by the Peter and Elizabeth C. Tower Foundation.



WHO WE ARE

Carole Carlson, Think College, Institute for Community Inclusion
carole.carlson@umb.edu | 617.287.4289

Jenn Bedore, Transition Specialist
Ludlow Public Schools

Patti Matthieu, Education/Job Coach
Ludlow Public Schools

Naomi Murdock, Transition Specialist
Agawam Public Schools

Sherry Elander, Transition Specialist
Westfield Public Schools

